¥328 billion in 2021–22. Its implementation record has been impressive, boasting so far of six metro rails in key Indian cities and a number of other major connectivity projects. What has also changed is a Japanese inclination to shape a more conducive infrastructure, expressed in its support for industrial and freight corridors. There are ongoing dialogues now in energy, space, steel, textile, start-up funding, digital skills and healthcare, among others.

The high-speed rail project from Mumbai to Ahmedabad stands out as the flagship initiative. Given its ripple impact, it can even be envisaged as the third technology revolution, following upon that of the Maruti-Suzuki car and the Delhi Metro. Similarly, while the ODA cooperation is a long-standing one, the Act East Forum established in 2017 specifically targets improved connectivity for India's Northeast.

But it is those familiar with the intricacies of Japanese society who are more likely to appreciate the progress with India. The yardsticks for that are examples of cooperation in domains of particular sensitivity. The 2016 agreement to cooperate on civil nuclear energy is an even more telling illustration of the growing comfort. No less significant are the series of understandings in the domain of defence and security. The 2014 agreement on defence cooperation was followed by those on equipment transfers and information protection in 2015, naval cooperation in 2018 and reciprocal supplies and services in 2020. Policy exchanges in defence have been supported by staff talks between services as well as bilateral and plurilateral military exercises. As with the US, India holds 2+2 ministerial meetings with Japan since 2019. Again, the bilateral comfort is beginning to be transposed on a wider canvas, starting predictably with the US and Australia.

Building a New Mateship

The relationship that has developed most visibly in recent times is that with Australia. Indeed, within a short space of time, it has narrowed the gap that stood out in comparison to the other two Quad members. As in the case of the US and Japan, the 1998 nuclear tests did impact ties and the road to recovery was also not an easy one. But the Australian relationship also carried its own unique challenges. It says something about India's priorities